considerable section of Adivasis with the ulterior motive is fraught with danger to the security of the State.

Crucially, ABVKA, along with Sangh pracharak Krishnarao Sapre and Bhimsen Chopra, and Hindu Mahasabha leaders,[46] assisted the Niyogi Commission in its meetings. The commission, which is often cited on Hindu nationalist websites,[47] claimed to have a record of nearly 4,000 conversions by Lutheran missionaries in Sarguja alone.[48] Its conclusions had a strong political impact in what is present-day Chhattisgarh, where the princely states of Sarguja and Raigarh had already enacted anti-conversion laws in the 1930s. The UN described the Niyogi Commission's charges as 'exaggerated',[49] but it became the ideational genesis of new anti-conversion laws that were enacted a decade later, in Odisha (1967), Madhya Pradesh (1968) and six other Indian states.[50]

The Ashram also began inviting religious leaders to Jashpur. The first among these were Rambhikshuji Maharaj, Swarupanandji Maharaj and Prabhuduttji Brahmachari.[51] The ABVKA's own account celebrates this intervention as a moment when 'after centuries, their religious brothers had knocked on the doors of vanvasis'. The arrival of Hindu religious leaders from other areas added a new layer to ABVKA's work on education. Long-time Sangh supporter and Lok Sabha TV CEO Ashish Joshi, who hails from Madhya Pradesh, pointed out that Deshpande began to counter Christian missionary work by placing statues of Hanuman, the monkey god, in tribal villages across Jashpur.[52] This strategy was seen as an important visual marker of what the Ashram saw as Hindu nationalist resistance. It was a key driving impulse for both Deshpande and his first patron, the ruler of Jashpur. By 1975, the Ashram had taken on two more core activities: medical care and financial aid to tribal communities.[53]

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